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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco Earthquake** was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history. It struck early in the morning with an estimated magnitude of about 7.8, rupturing the **San Andreas Fault** over hundreds of miles.

What happened

- **Severe shaking** lasted less than a minute but caused widespread structural collapse across **San Francisco** and surrounding areas.
- **Fires** broke out almost immediately due to ruptured gas lines and damaged infrastructure. These fires burned for three days and destroyed much of the city.
- Around **3,000 people died**, and over **200,000 were left homeless**—more than half the city's population at the time.

What shaped today's San Francisco landscape

1. Fire, more than the quake itself

The post-quake fires leveled entire neighborhoods, especially downtown. This allowed large sections of the city to be **rebuilt from scratch**, influencing:

- Street layouts
- Building density
- Commercial vs. residential zones

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2. New building codes and seismic design

The disaster led to major advances in **earthquake engineering**:

- Stronger building codes
- Use of steel-frame construction
- Ongoing seismic retrofitting standards still used today

This is why modern San Francisco buildings are far more earthquake-resistant.

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3. Urban planning and infrastructure redesign

Reconstruction efforts reshaped the city:

- Improved water systems (critical after firefighting failures)
- Broader streets in some areas
- More organized city planning, though some ambitious redesign plans were never fully realized

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4. Population shifts and regional growth

Displaced residents moved to nearby areas, accelerating development across the Bay Area, including places like **Oakland** and **Berkeley**. This helped turn the region into a multi-city metropolitan area rather than one centered solely on San Francisco.

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5. Scientific understanding of earthquakes

The event helped scientists better understand fault movement:

- Confirmed the idea of tectonic stress and release along faults
- Laid groundwork for modern seismology

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6. Lasting geographic and visual impacts

- Some neighborhoods were rebuilt differently or shifted in character
- Land use patterns (industrial vs. residential) were redefined

- Infrastructure like transit and utilities were modernized

Bottom line

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it **reset it**. The fires, rebuilding decisions, and new engineering practices fundamentally shaped the modern city's layout, safety standards, and even the broader development of the Bay Area.

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